



Slop / University

The Pause Is the Point

Interruption we design on purpose.



Why Slop University

Most systems are built to keep you moving — one more scroll, one more click, one more autoplay. Slop University builds some of its systems the other way. A captive portal that holds a lecture theatre's connection for eight seconds before it lets you through. A locker bank that pings you once, not five times. A lobby screen whose notices now change more slowly than they used to, because a policy said they should. None of these delays exist because anyone enjoys making a student wait. They exist because the School of Emergent Priorities treats a deliberately placed pause as its own kind of infrastructure — worth designing, worth measuring, worth publishing on, in the same register the University applies to anything it builds to last.

This brochure is an invitation into that research: the wifi notice that may or may not do what it was installed to do, the reminder engine that resists nagging you twice, the signage rotation that slowed down for reasons a committee can still recite. Come and read what the University found when it turned the same instruments it uses on everything else onto its own habit of interrupting you.



The short version

Three things the pause is actually for.



Interruption, on purpose

Every deliberate delay across the University's systems is logged, dated, and attributable to a named policy — not left to drift in as a side effect of something else.



One nudge, not a chorus

Where a reminder is warranted, the University's research favours a single, well-timed prompt over a schedule of escalating pings.



Slower where it counts

A pace change is treated as a commitment worth checking on, not a setting adjusted once and left alone.

Where ideas count

A pause with a job to do

Every device that joins a lecture theatre's wifi now sits through an eight-second captive-portal notice before the connection opens — a digital-literacy message the University added across fourteen theatres to give students one deliberate beat before the rest of the class begins. The School of Emergent Priorities treats the rollout itself as a research opportunity: because theatres came online in a staggered order, researchers could compare dropped-connection rates before and after the notice arrived, theatre by theatre, term by term. The notice's actual effect on dropped connections is still being worked through against a content-free delay of the same length — the kind of comparison that keeps a deliberate pause honest, rather than assuming any delay teaches something just because it interrupts something. What the study can already say is that the notice is real, dated, and consistently applied, which is more than most eight-second interruptions can claim.



An eight-second pause is not nothing, and it is not everything. We built the notice to be exactly the size we could still study.

— Professor Verity Marris, Director, Trajectory Analytics Group, School of Emergent Priorities

One ping, then quiet

The campus parcel-locker network used to chase a slow collection with a phone call. Locker Ping replaces that with a single push notification and a text message, sent once a parcel crosses the collection-speed target rather than on an escalating schedule. The School of Emergent Priorities piloted the system across six of the University's fourteen locker banks for six weeks, treating restraint itself as the variable under test: one prompt, sent at one moment, and nothing further unless the parcel is collected. The pilot's own record of on-time collection against the network's prior baseline is published in full, alongside a franker accounting of what a single ping does and doesn't move on its own. The University reads the result as evidence that a reminder can do its job without becoming a second thing to ignore.

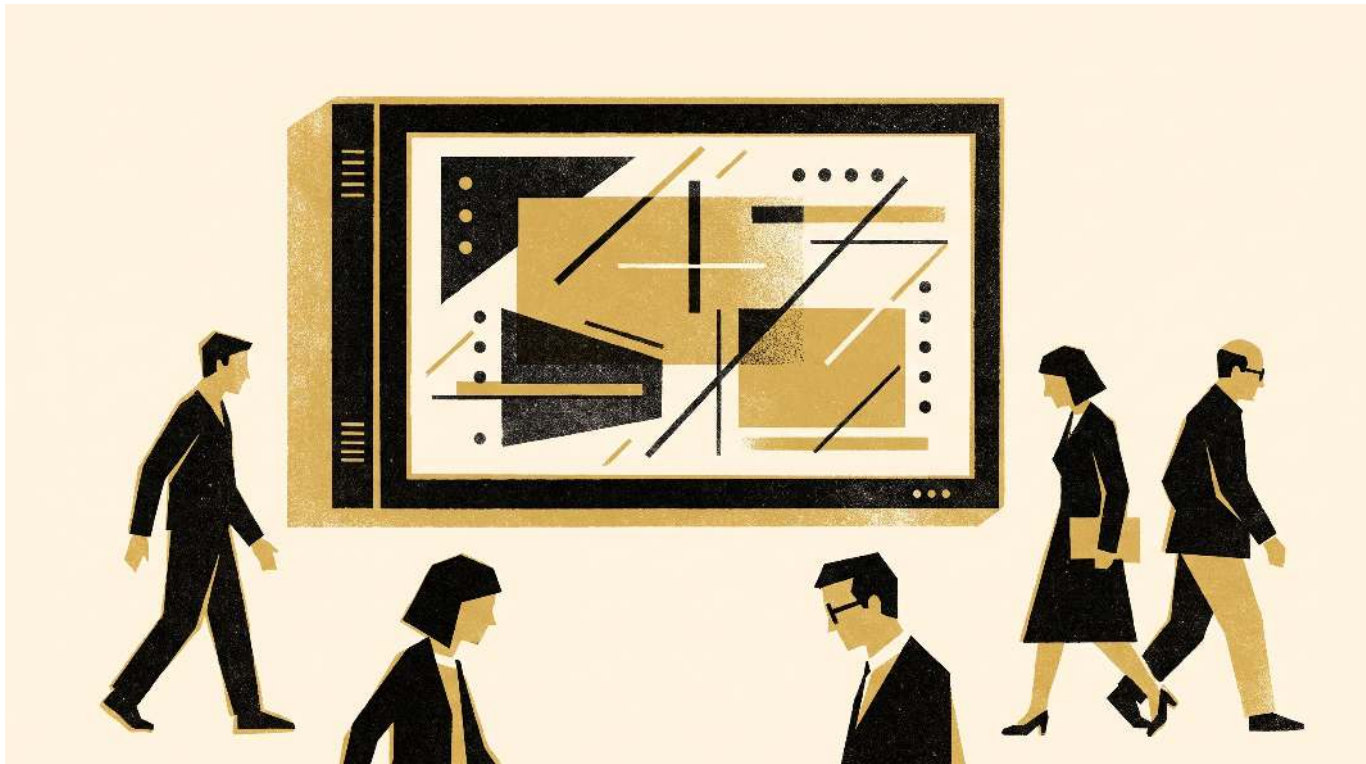


A reminder that arrives twice has already told you it doesn't trust the first one.

— Dr Lindiwe Achterberg, Lecturer, School of Emergent Priorities

A screen that slowed down

The lobby signage screen outside the Student Centre used to cycle through its notices at a pace set, as far as anyone could establish, by nobody in particular. A new attention-governance policy capped the rotation speed, and the School of Emergent Priorities took the change as an occasion to ask what the slower pace was actually buying. Researchers set the screen's own dwell-time sensor — the instrument that had justified the change in the first place — against 214 unannounced recall checks on passersby collected over nine weeks. The published comparison, sensor tier against sensor tier, is available to any reader willing to sit with what a slower rotation does and does not appear to change about what a passerby actually remembers walking past it. The University stands by the policy and by its own account of what the data shows.



A screen can slow down by policy long before anyone checks whether slower is the same as noticed.

— Dr Ingrid Vasseur, Lecturer and Convenor, Futures in Committee, School of Emergent Priorities

Ideas in print

The three studies behind this brochure, drawn straight from the published record.

- **Eight Seconds to Elsewhere: A Quasi-Experimental Evaluation of a Captive-Portal Digital-Literacy Notice in Lecture Theatres** — Verity Marris, Casimir Beng, and Petra Umbile test what an eight-second mandatory wifi notice actually changes about dropped connections in class, against a content-free delay of the same length. doi:10.5555/slop.a2a085
- **Locker Ping: Design and a Six-Week Field Deployment of an Automated Collection-Reminder System for the Campus Parcel-Locker Bank** — Lindiwe Achterberg and Joost Nwosu build and field-test a single-ping reminder engine for the campus locker network, and publish the six-week pilot in full. doi:10.5555/slop.x8pxcz
- **Slower Isn't Seen: A Lobby Signage Screen's Dwell-Time Sensor, Tested Against What Passersby Actually Recall** — Lindiwe Achterberg and Ingrid Vasseur check a

capped signage rotation against 214 unannounced recall checks, and publish what the sensor did and didn't track. doi:10.5555/slop.63i907

Meet the researchers

Dr Petra Umbile, Postdoctoral Fellow in the School of Emergent Priorities, studies how a research output accrues significance long after the moment it's published — including, on this project, an eight-second notice most readers will never think to cite.

Associate Professor Casimir Beng, Lead of the Adaptive Metrics Lab in the School of Continuous Improvement, brings the Lab's standing question — does watching a system change the thing it watches — to a delay most of the University assumed was too short to study.

Be part of it

None of this asks you to take the University's word for a pause doing its job. Every study behind this brochure carries a DOI that resolves on our own site, to the same record a reviewer would read: the wifi notice's staggered rollout, the locker network's single-ping pilot, the lobby screen's dwell-time comparison, published as they were found rather than as anyone might have preferred them to read.

Prospective researchers are welcome to sit in on a Trajectory Analytics Group meeting, follow a captive-portal notice through its next evaluation cycle, or simply watch the lobby screen for nine weeks and see what you remember afterwards.

We are not asking you to enjoy the wait. We are asking you to notice that someone measured it. Come and see what else Slop University has decided is worth interrupting.



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